

The Friedman Team's First Time Buyer's Checklist 15 Steps to Your Front Door

Carroll, Baltimore & Howard County

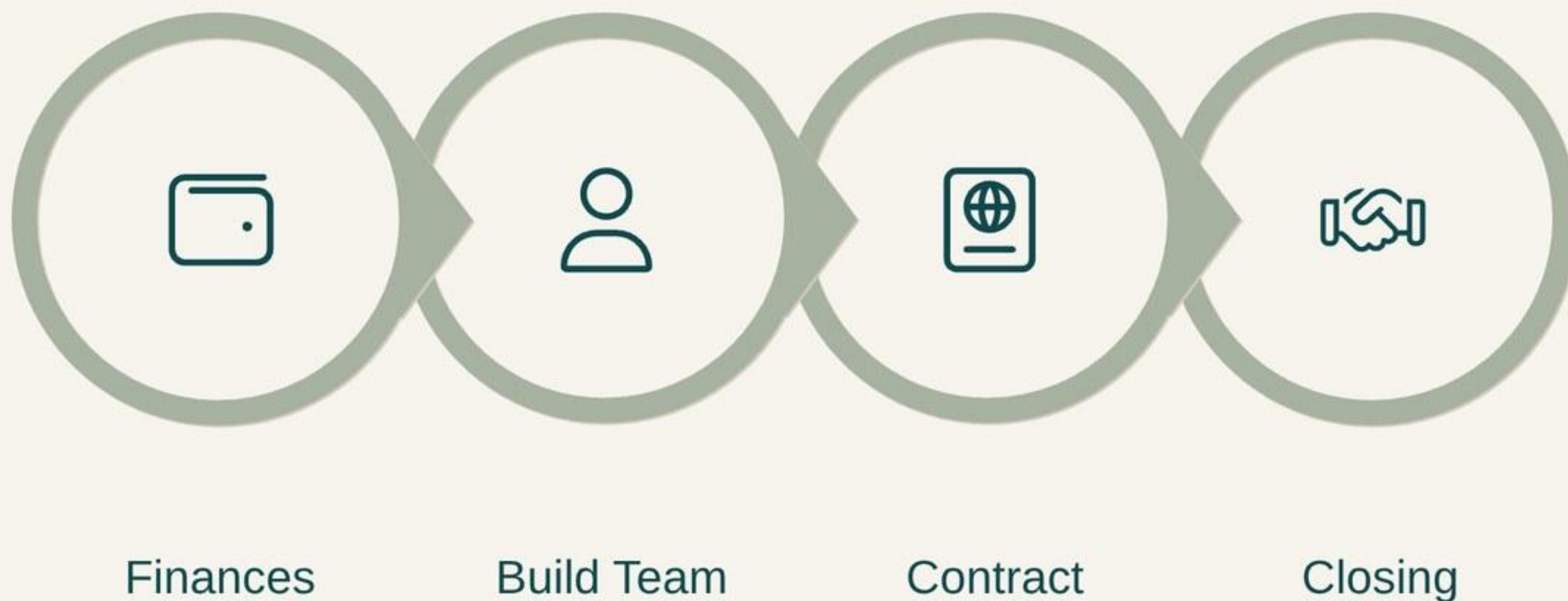
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Your Roadmap to Homeownership

Whether you're eyeing a rowhome in Baltimore County, a colonial in Carroll County, or something close to Columbia in Howard County, this is the roadmap I walk every first-time buyer through – fifteen steps, four phases, from pre-approval to keys in hand.



\$ PHASE 1

Get Your Finances Right First

Step 1: Know Your Real Number

Lender approval and what you can comfortably afford are two different things — taxes vary across Baltimore, Carroll, and Howard counties. Keep your debt-to-income ratio under 43% and factor in any HOA fees.

Step 2: Your Down Payment Is Smaller Than You Think

Most first-time buyers put down 3–5%, and the Maryland Mortgage Program offers 0%-interest down payment assistance. Budget an additional 2–5% for closing costs like transfer taxes and title insurance.

Step 3: Clean Up Your Credit Before You Apply

Pay card balances below 30% utilization to secure the best interest rate. Avoid opening new credit or financing anything while your loan is in process — lenders re-check before closing.

Build Your Team, Start Looking

1

Work With Someone Who Knows These Counties

Septic systems, ground rent, and county quirks require a hyper-local agent.

2

Get Pre-Approved, Not Just Pre-Qualified

Sellers in competitive markets won't consider offers without a verified pre-approval.

3

Research the Actual Neighborhood

Test the commute at rush hour and check internet availability before committing.

4

Separate Must-Haves From Nice-to-Haves

Lock in non-negotiables early, including water/sewer versus well and septic.

5

Start Touring, and Look Past the Paint

Focus on roof, windows, and HVAC — not staging or cosmetics.

PHASE 3

The Contract

Step 9: Make a Real Offer, Not a Guess

I pull actual comparable sales so your offer is grounded in real data, not a feeling. Your contingencies — financing, appraisal, inspection — are your protection if something doesn't check out.

Step 10: Negotiate Like a Conversation, Not a Fight

First-time buyers often ask sellers to cover a portion of closing costs, keeping more cash available for moving day. Counter-offers are normal, not a red flag.

Step 11: Never Skip the Inspection

Radon testing is recommended every time, and wood-destroying insect inspections are standard — often required by lenders. In rural Carroll County, a well and septic inspection is non-negotiable.

Step 12: The Appraisal Is Your Safety Net

Your lender orders an independent appraisal to confirm the home is worth what you're paying. If it comes in low, you can renegotiate the price, cover the gap, or walk away.

🔑 PHASE 4

Closing

01

Step 13: Your Loan Gets Its Final Check

The underwriter issues "Clear to Close" after a final review. Your Closing Disclosure arrives at least three days before settlement with your exact cash-to-close amount.

02

Step 14: Title Work Catches What You Can't See

I check for Maryland-specific issues like ground rent and front foot benefit charges – surprises that can show up as unexpected annual bills.

03

Step 15: Maryland Does "Wet" Settlements

All parties sign together in one session. Funds transfer immediately and you walk out with keys the same day.

📄 Ready to start? I'm happy to walk through your specific situation – just reach out.

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What Kyle's Clients Can Expect

Kyle works harder, markets smarter, and never stops until the job is done.

01

Honest Guidance

Straight talk about your situation so you can make the best decision.

02

Strategic Insight

Data-driven pricing, positioning, and negotiation tailored to your goals.

03

Relentless Follow Up

Kyle proactively pursues every lead and opportunity on your behalf.

04

Real Results

More views, stronger offers, faster closings, and more money in your pocket.

Let's Talk

Ready to get started? Kyle is ready to go to work for you.



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Kyle Friedman

Licensed Realtor® | Expert Negotiator
Owner, Founder / **The Friedman Team at EXP Realty**

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Why Choose Kyle?

🏆 **80% more views** than comparable listings

☎️ **5,000+ calls/month** to find your buyer

🎬 **Cinematic video** and best in class photography

★ **Zillow Showcase** premium placement

📊 **Investor mindset** on every deal since 2018

Equal Housing Opportunity. Kyle Friedman is a licensed real estate salesperson in Maryland affiliated with EXP Realty. All information is deemed reliable but not guaranteed and should be independently verified.